5 ways to relieve pain from shoulder impingement

by Richard Rhodes, MD
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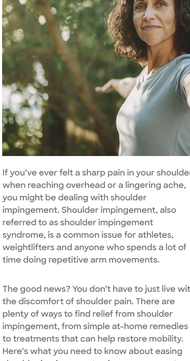

If you've ever felt a sharp pain in your shoulder when reaching overhead or a lingering ache, you might be dealing with shoulder impingement. Shoulder impingement, also referred to as shoulder impingement syndrome, is a common issue for athletes, weightlifters and anyone who spends a lot of time doing repetitive arm movements.

The good news? You don't have to just live with the discomfort of shoulder pain. There are plenty of ways to find relief from shoulder impingement, from simple at-home remedies to treatments that can help restore mobility. Here's what you need to know about easing shoulder impingement pain so you can get back to moving comfortably.

Understanding shoulder impingement syndrome

First, let's discuss what shoulder impingement is and what causes it. Shoulder impingement syndrome occurs when the tendons or bursa in the shoulder joint become compressed or irritated, leading to pain and restricted movement.

This happens in the narrow space between the top of the shoulder blade and the rotator cuff tendons. When you lift your arm, these structures can get pinched, causing inflammation, swelling and discomfort.

The most common causes of shoulder impingement include repetitive overhead movements, poor posture and muscle imbalances. Athletes who play sports like swimming, baseball or tennis are particularly prone to it, as are people who do a lot of lifting or reaching in their daily activities.

Poor shoulder mechanics—often due to weak stabilizing muscles—can also contribute to shoulder impingement by allowing improper movement of the shoulder joint. Additionally, aging and arthritis can lead to structural changes that make shoulder impingement more likely.

Pain relief strategies for shoulder impingement

Dealing with shoulder impingement can be frustrating, but the good news is there are ways to find relief. Let's discuss a few effective home remedies, as well as surgical options for shoulder impingement treatment.

1. Rest

   The most important step when dealing with pain of any kind, including pain from shoulder impingement, is to rest. Rest allows your body to recover and heal. Avoid activities that involve repetitive overhead movements, heavy lifting or anything that worsens your pain. Focus on modifying your daily tasks to reduce strain on the joint but keep in mind that gentle movement is encouraged to avoid becoming stiff.

2. Anti-inflammatory medications

   Over-the-counter nonsteroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs), such as ibuprofen or naproxen, can help reduce pain and swelling from shoulder impingement. These medications work by decreasing inflammation in the affected tendons and bursa, making movement more comfortable.

   Always follow the recommended dosage and consult a doctor or pharmacist if you have any questions before taking a new medication.

3. Physical therapy and stretching

   Targeted shoulder impingement exercises and stretches can improve shoulder mobility and strengthen the surrounding muscles, helping prevent further impingement.

   While exercises at home may help, you may also want to ask your doctor about seeing a physical therapist. They can create a personalized program for you that includes stretching and strengthening exercises to help your muscles recover and prevent future shoulder impingement issues.

4. Steroid injections

   If you're experiencing persistent or severe pain from shoulder impingement syndrome, your doctor may recommend a corticosteroid injection. This anti-inflammatory medication is injected directly into the shoulder joint to provide temporary relief by reducing inflammation and swelling.

   While effective, steroid injections should be used cautiously, as repeated use can weaken tendons over time. Your doctor can help you decide whether steroid injections are right for you.

5. Surgery

   Fortunately, these conservative treatments are typically enough to resolve shoulder impingement and relieve pain for most people. However, if your pain lingers, surgery may be a good option.

   The most common procedure for shoulder impingement is a subacromial decompression, during which a surgeon removes bone spurs or trims the top of your shoulder blade (acromion) to create more space for the rotator cuff. This can help eliminate the source of impingement and restore pain-free movement.

   Surgery is typically considered a last resort when other treatments have failed. Your doctor can guide you through treatment options and advise on when surgery may be a good option for you.

When to see a doctor for shoulder impingement treatment

If your pain from shoulder impingement persists despite rest, stretching and over-the-counter treatments, it may be time to see a doctor. You should also seek medical attention if your pain is severe or interferes with daily activities.

Other warning signs include weakness in the shoulder, difficulty lifting your arm, or a clicking or popping sensation when moving it. If you've had a recent injury or suspect a rotator cuff tear, prompt evaluation can help prevent further damage from shoulder impingement.

Your doctor can recommend imaging tests if needed and help you find the best treatment plan for long-term relief from shoulder impingement syndrome.

About the Author

Richard Rhodes, MD, is an orthopedic sports medicine physician on the medical staff at Baylor Scott & White Sports Therapy & Research at The Star. Dr. Rhodes specializes in arthroscopic and reconstructive surgery of the shoulder and knee.